EXTREME MEASURES

Snapdragon 8 Elite vs Elite Extreme Gen 6: Who really needs the Extreme?

Picking a Snapdragon-based Android flagship was fairly simple, because there was only one top-tier chip to contend with year after year, something that every brand's hero phone ran on. That has certainty ended at Snapdragon Summit 2026.

Breaking from tradition (and borrowing a leaf from its X2 Elite announcements last year), Qualcomm didn't just unveil a single successor to last year's Snapdragon 8 Elite Gen 5. It made things very interesting by unveiling two top-class variants – the Snapdragon 8 Elite Gen 6 and an even more powerful version of it, the Snapdragon 8 Elite Extreme Gen 6. If the



"Extreme" tag sounds familiar, that's because Qualcomm first used it on its X2 Elite Extreme laptop chip.

What's important to note here is that both the Snapdragon 8 Elite Gen 6 and Extreme chips share the same CPU, the same underlying 2nm process and the modem. Let's analyse what extra oomph and muscle the Extreme brings and where the Gen 6 leaves you short-changed, if at all.

Same heart, new muscle

Let's start with what's common between the Snapdragon 8 Elite Gen 6 vs Elite Extreme Gen 6, because there's quite a lot. TSMC's 2nm process is common to both the chip variants, so is Qualcomm's latest Oryon CPU – which has two Prime cores clocked up to 5GHz and six Performance cores up to 4GHz, backed by 16MB of shared Oryon Flex Cache. Both of these are the world's first smartphone chips to cross the 5GHz barrier, in case you didn't notice.

Both chips also have these things in common: LPDDR6/LPDDR5X support up to 24GB, UFS 5.0 storage, triple 20-bit AI ISPs capable of 320MP photos, the X105 5G modem with satellite connectivity, Wi-Fi 8, and triple-frequency GNSS with NavIC support – a welcome touch for Indian users.

Even the CPU gap is slim. Qualcomm claims the Extreme's CPU is 13% faster than the 8 Elite Gen 5, compared to 10% on the standard Gen 6. And both the chip variants promise 37% better CPU power efficiency. That difference isn't going to show up if you're just going to be scrolling Instagram or doing UPI transactions, by the way.

The Extreme pulls away

The real separation between the two Snapdragon 8 Elite Gen 6 and Extreme Gen 6 chips shows up in three key areas – graphics, AI and video. And that's where it matters the most.

On the graphics front, the Extreme's Adreno GPU is 44% faster than last year, against 35% on the standard Gen 6. Important to note is that only the Extreme gets 18MB of dedicated Adreno High Performance Memory and Adreno Matrix Cores – AI units built into the GPU. These power Adreno Neural Fusion, essentially Qualcomm's take on DLSS-style upscaling and AI frame generation.

tinyurl.com/nzv8zxbz

Snapdragon Sound Elite Gen 2: Qualcomm is building an OS for your ears

Buying headphones is one of the few technology purchases you can still make by instinct rather than having specs opened in a new tab somewhere else. Not anymore, though, with the Snapdragon Sound Elite Gen 2.



The spec sheet mentions enhanced ANC and lossless audio, and yes, both of those are there. However, there is much more going on, as this time around Qualcomm does not treat its audio wearable technology as an accessory to your phone, but as a computer on its own. This computer features a Wi-Fi 6E radio, allowing a pair of earbuds or smart glasses to communicate directly with the cloud, bypassing any other device on the way. A dedicated AI accelerator, processing at 128 GOPS and doubling the capacity of the previous generation. There is even a whole "Apps & Agents" platform that Qualcomm encourages OEMs to develop on this platform. Radio, AI chip, and apps – all integrated into a single chipset previously used only for transferring audio signals to your headphones.

tinyurl.com/dp4x7vxt